



SIPRA DAS

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM | Theatre of the Absurd

Those who see politics as another form of entertainment will be delighted with the goings-on in Kerala. Barely has the controversy over his remarks at martyred Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan's house in Bangalore settled that Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan finds himself in the midst of another equally embarrassing one. His private secretary S. Rajendran, a nominee of the CPI(M), has accused a powerful "coterie" at the chief minister's office (CMO) of sabotaging government initiatives. The remarks have invited retribution from a state IAS officer, K. Suresh Kumar, who defied service rules to accuse the chief minister's personal staff of sabotage. "Crucial files concerning the proposed Rs 1,500-crore Smart City project and the controversial Killiroor sex scandal case were not taken up by Rajendran," said Kumar. He added that neither Rajendran nor K.N. Balagopal (political secretary to the chief minister) have ever helped Achuthanandan. The IAS officer was additional private secretary to Achuthanandan till last year when he was transferred after his controversial role in the demolition of illegal structures at Munnar. "Ever since Achuthanandan assumed office in 2006, the CMO has been a battleground for the CPI(M)'s factional feuds involving supporters of the chief minister and those of powerful party state secretary Pinarayi Vijayan. While the CPI(M) took the unprecedented step of suspending both from the Politburo, which was later revoked, party bosses in Delhi remain mute witnesses, not wanting to antagonise the senior leaders when general elections are only months away. *by Shafi Rahman*

CONTROVER-
SIES DON'T
SEEM TO LEAVE
ACHUTHANAN-
DAN (ABOVE)
ALONE

12

BJP ministers and Speaker Sumitra Singh lost in the Rajasthan Assembly polls as the saffron party was ousted from power.